

A question of choice

IT WAS NEVER about serving your best interests nor about doing it for the betterment of humanity. No matter how a company tries to portray its next greatest venture, they're only doing it because they want to make money. Companies are always answerable to a select few individuals who sit on the board and we haven't come across in any instance where a company put down a massive investment with no profit in sight. The money will come sooner or later but it will come. Facebook's Cambridge Analytica scandal is something we had foreseen ages ago. We weren't the only ones, practically anyone acquainted with the tech industry knew that privacy was only a word to be thrown around to assuage the doubts of the slightly cautious folk. The paranoid ones were never convinced and never will be.

It's not just free services, but when a company says that they love competition, they're lying. No businessman likes competition, the high frequency of hostile takeovers attests to that fact. Sometimes companies don't even attempt to compete, they've either joined hands to screw the consumer over like how major LCD panel manufacturers got together to fix prices of LCD panels in televisions, laptops and monitors. Then there are times when they formed secret agreements with OEMs to ensure that the competition's offerings are not used. There's an ongoing battle in the EU where Intel is alleged to have given rebates to computer makers from 2002 to 2005 provided they brought 95% of their CPUs from Intel. The makers included Acer, Dell, HP, Lenovo, etc.

We're now seeing yet another such agreement propping up, this time it's from NVIDIA. Obviously, NVIDIA has said absolutely nothing about the GPP (GeForce Partner Program) but based on what has been reported in the media so far, we can see it in action. These allegations against NVIDIA became more believable after a blog post by AMD's Scott Herkelman where he advocates for gamers to have the freedom of choice when it comes to purchasing PC components. While he hasn't named NVIDIA openly, it's pretty clear that he's talking about NVIDIA's GPP.

So what's GPP? Well, the terms of GPP have been kept extremely secretive but a few insiders have leaked information to international press wherein NVIDIA supposedly promises GPP partners get priority allocation of premium GPUs while non-partners would be limited from releasing graphics cards based on those GPUs. Moreover, GPP partners will get access to marketing funds and will have to align their gaming brand exclusively with NVIDIA. Now this affects both AMD and Intel. It affects AMD because Radeon cards will not be sold under the same brand as NVIDIA cards. In case of ASUS, which is supposedly a GPP partner, they can't have any ROG Radeon cards, ROG will have to be exclusively NVIDIA. This obviously puts ASUS in a fix and as a result ASUS recently came out with the AREZ brand for Radeon products. However, the damage here is that the ROG brand has been built over the years and is well known. The new AREZ brand will require a lot more effort from ASUS to equal the ROG brand.

GPP affects Intel because all partners will not be able to use the new Kabylake-G CPUs with in-built AMD Vega graphics. Kabylake-G has been shown to be very promising and poses a major threat to NVIDIA's hold over the gaming laptop market. It's been a couple of months since Kabylake-G was announced but we're yet to see any laptops with Kabylake-G except Intel's own NUCs. Only brands such as Dell and HP, who reportedly have not signed GPP, have announced Kabylake-G products. Every day, we're seeing more and more news pointing to the finger at NVIDIA for the lack of Kabylake-G laptops in the market.

GPP, if it truly exists, is thoroughly anti-competitive. Since both NVIDIA and their supposed partners have been tight-lipped about the program we can't say anything more. All we can hope is for regulatory agencies to swoop in and save the day but if regulatory agencies are like the FCC in its current avatar, then there isn't much hope to begin with. We're doomed people! Be ready to pay through your nose for the next enthusiast PC component because if GPP is allowed to fly, then everyone else will follow suit. **d**



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